

Session 17: Do Not Judge

Key Takeaways

- The Greek word *krino* ("to judge") ranges in meaning from a positive discernment to a negative condemnation.
- Jesus knows we will face moments when we think we need to make a judgment. He wants us to see these as opportunities to first examine ourselves, then to consider whether the situation we are facing will benefit from our discernment or whether making a determination will only stir up conflict.
- The words "pig" and "dog" were commonly used in Jesus' time to negatively refer to non-Israelites, but Jesus' interactions with non-Israelites (see Matthew 15:21-39) should guard against an overly simplistic reading of how he used those words.

Loving Your Neighbor

Matthew 7:1-6

7:1-2

A - **Don't** condemn, so that you are not condemned ($\mu\eta$ + imperative)

- The inverted nature of judgment in relationships
- With the measure you measure it will be measured to you ($\acute{\upsilon}\mu\iota\nu$)

7:3-5

B - **Parable about two eyes:** the speck and the beam in the eye

7:6

A' - **Parable about two kinds:** **Don't** give holy pearls to pig-dogs

Matthew 7:7-11

B'' - Ask, seek, knock, because your Father loves to give good gifts

Matthew 7:12

A' - **Do** to people what you desire them to do to you (imperative + $\acute{\upsilon}\mu\iota\nu$)

- The inverted nature of the golden rule: "This is the Torah and Prophets" (link back to **Matt. 6:17-20**)

Matthew 7:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

A

a 7:1 **Do not judge**,
 b so that you will not **be judged**,

a' 2 because with the **judgment** that you **judge**
 b' you will **be judged**,

a" and with the measure that you **measure**
 b" it will **be measured** to you.

B

a 3 Why do you **see the speck** in **the eye of your brother**,
 but you don't **perceive the beam** in your eye!
 b 4 Or, how can you say to **your brother**,
 "Allow me **to take out the speck** from **your eye**."

c And look, **the beam** is in **your eye** !

b' 5 Hypocrite! First **take out the beam from your eye**,
 a' and then you can **see-clearly the speck** in **the eye of your brother** .

A'

a 6 **Do not give** what is holy to **dogs**,
 b and don't throw your pearls in front of **pigs**,
 b' so **they** don't trample them with their feet,
 a' and turning around, **they** will tear you apart.

A

a 7 **Ask** and it will be **given** to you,
 b **seek** and you will **find**,
 c **knock** and it will be **opened** for you,
 a' 8 for everyone who asks will receive,
 b' and the one who **seeks** will **find**,
 c' and to the one who **knocks** it will be **opened**.

B a ⁹ Or, what person is among you
b who, when **their son** **asks** for bread,
c will he **give** him a rock?

B' b' ¹⁰ Or, when he **asks** for a fish,
c' will he **give** him a snake?

C a ¹¹ So then, if you all are bad,
b but you know to **give** **good gifts** to **your children**,
a' how **much more** **your Father in the skies**,
b' he will **give** **good things** to those who **ask**.

¹² So then, everything you desire
that **people to do to you**,
so **also you do to them**;
for this is the **Torah and the Prophets**.

Matthew 7:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Do Not Condemn

A a ^{7:1} **Do not** **judge**,
b so that you will not **be judged**,

a' ² because with the **judgment** that you **judge**
b' you will **be judged**,

a" and with the measure that you **measure**
b" it will **be measured** to you.

Matthew 7:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Jesus begins with a general prohibition, which is intentionally open-ended. The generality is clarified and unpacked in the parable that follows in 7:3-6. However, it's important to first take in what this opening

statement means on its own.

“Do not judge” (Greek: *μὴ κρίνετε*) is a rhetorically powerful and categorical statement aimed at addressing all areas of life and relationships. He intends his words about judging to have a universal scope. However, given what he is about to say, this cannot possibly be a comprehensive prohibition that forbids all forms of decision making and moral judgments. The closest evidence for this claim is the list of clarifications that follow in 7:3-6, which is all about making moral evaluations of oneself and others. To evaluate “the beam in one’s own eye” requires a judgment, just as discerning whether or not to offer wisdom to another person requires careful judgment. While the rhetorical purpose of this opening line is extreme, it’s clear from the immediate context that Jesus is prohibiting a specific way or manner of making moral judgments.

In Matthew, Jesus is portrayed as someone who lives out his own teachings with total consistency, and Jesus clearly made judgments about the behavior of other people (like the Pharisees and Bible scribes in Matthew 23, for example).

Jesus also makes clear in the following parables that there is an appropriate time and place for “taking out the speck” of your brother’s eye (7:3-5) and for deciding that your feedback won’t be received well (7:6). The import of these parables is that only after a lot of self-critical judgment should one undertake to evaluate the behavior of others.

People often use wide-scale prohibitions as a rhetorical device to make clear how seriously we mean what we say. As an illustration, if a parent tells their child, “Do not yell at your sibling,” it’s clear that they mean yelling out of anger or frustration. But if the child sees their sibling running into a busy street and no parent is around, it is definitely okay to yell, “Look out! Come back!”

So what is the specific manner of judgment that Jesus is prohibiting here?

The word “judge” is the Greek word *krino* (*κρίνω*), and the noun “judgment” is *krima*, which in Second Temple Jewish Greek corresponds to the Hebrew words *shapat* (*שפט*), “to judge,” and *mishpat* (*משפט*), “judgment.”

Krino is the most general word for evaluating someone’s behavior and forming a judgment about it. That is, making a decision or conclusion based on that evaluation.

Within this general idea, there are more specific nuances to the word *krino* as used in the New Testament and the Old Greek Septuagint.

Moral Discernment: Deciding Between Good or Bad, Right or Wrong

Acts 4:19–20 NASB*

But Peter and John answered and said to them, “Whether it is right in the sight of God to give heed to you rather than to God, you be the one to ***krino***; for we cannot stop speaking about what we have seen and heard.”

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Making a Decision Based on Multiple Alternatives: Good vs. Best

Acts 15:19 NASB*

Therefore it is my **krisis** that we do not trouble those who are turning to God from among the Gentiles,

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Acts 20:16 NASB*

For Paul had **krino** to sail past Ephesus so that he would not have to spend time in Asia; for he was hurrying to be in Jerusalem, if possible, on the day of Pentecost.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Making a Pronouncement About Someone's Status in a Court or Social Setting

John 8:10–11 NASB*

Straightening up, Jesus said to her, "Woman, where are they? Did no one **condemn (katakrimo)** you?" She said, "No one, Lord." And Jesus said, "I do not **judge (krino)** you, either. Go. From now on sin no more."

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

John 18:31 NASB*

So Pilate said to them, "Take him yourselves, and **krino** him according to your law." The Jews said to him, "We are not permitted to put anyone to death,"

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Acts 25:9–10 NASB*

But Festus, wishing to do the Jews a favor, answered Paul and said, "Are you willing to go up to Jerusalem and be **krino'd** before me on these charges?"

But Paul said, "I am standing before Caesar's tribunal, where I ought to be **krino'd**. I have done no wrong to the Jews, as you also very well know."

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

God's Verdict on a Person/Group

John 12:47–48 NIV*

If anyone hears my words but does not keep them, I do not **krino** that person. For I did not come to **krino** the world, but to save the world.

There is a **krino** for the one who rejects me and does not accept my words; the very words I have spoken will **krino** them at the last day.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Acts 17:30–31 NASB*

Therefore having overlooked the times of ignorance, God is now declaring to men that all people everywhere should repent, because he has fixed a day in which he will **krino** the world in righteousness through a man whom he has appointed, having furnished proof to all men by raising him from the dead.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Passages That Bring Various Meanings Together

Romans 2:1–3 NASB*

Therefore you have no excuse, everyone of you who **passes judgment**, for in that which you **judge** another, you **condemn (katakrimo)** yourself; for you who **judge** practice the same things.

And we know that the **judgment** of God rightly falls upon those who practice such things.

But do you suppose this, O man, when you pass judgment on those who practice such things and do the same yourself, that you will escape the **judgment** of God?

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Romans 14:4–5 NASB*

Who are you to **judge** the servant of another?

To his own master he stands or falls; and he will stand, for the Lord is able to make him stand.

One person **judges** one day above another, another **judges** every day alike.

Each person must be fully convinced in his own mind.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

It seems clear that Jesus had this last nuance of meaning in mind: Jesus is prohibiting the act of taking upon oneself the prerogative to pronounce final or ultimate judgment on another person, presuming to have a divine vantage point on a person's character and motives.

This saying of Jesus was clearly influential on early Christianity, as the apostles regularly adopted and adapted the teaching in various ways, always clarifying what they understood Jesus to mean.

Romans 14:10 NASB

But you, why do you judge your brother? Or you again, why do you regard your brother with contempt? For we will all stand before the judgment seat of God.

1 Corinthians 4:5 NASB

Therefore do not go on **passing judgment** before the time, but **wait until the Lord comes** who will both bring to light the things hidden in the darkness **and disclose the motives of men's hearts**; and then each man's praise will come to him from God.

2 Corinthians 5:10 NASB

For we must all appear before **the judgment seat of Christ**, so that each one may be recompensed for his deeds in the body, according to what he has done, whether good or bad.

James 4:11–12 NASB

Do not **speak against one another**, brethren. He who speaks against a brother or **judges** his brother, speaks against the law and **judges** the law. ... There is only one Lawgiver and **Judge**, the One who is able to save and to destroy; but who are you who **judge** your neighbor?

The problem James is addressing is Christians taking it upon themselves to pronounce God's judgment on another person.

“James warns his readers that when they begin to judge (condemn) others, they are assuming the posture of God, not the posture of humans. In assuming that posture, they have usurped the role of God and begun to be the ones who determine what is right and wrong, and who is right and who is wrong.”

McKnight, Scot (2013). [*Sermon on the Mount \(The Story of God Bible Commentary\)*](#). Zondervan.

“Jesus warns his disciples against setting themselves over others and making a pronouncement of their guilt before God. We should be careful in making these kinds of judgments, because we too will be judged for committing a sin worse than that which we are accusing.”

Wilkins, Michael J. (2003). [*Matthew \(The NIV Application Commentary\)*](#). Zondervan Academic. 308.

“‘Do not judge’ (μὴ κρίνετε) implies that the individual, acting upon what Luther called ‘self-centered wisdom’, is playing the judge (cf. Jn. 5:30). He is taking up a role he should not be playing because it is reserved for the only capable judge, God. (Cf. 13:36–43, 47–50, where the sorting out of evil from good awaits the great assize). Thus κρίνω is almost synonymous with κατακρίνω = ‘condemn’ (cf. 12:41–42; 20:18; Rom. 2:1, 3). This inference is borne out by the meaning of the verb in the second half of the present clause. ‘Do not judge, lest ye be judged’, means, ‘Do not judge, lest ye be condemned [by God at the final judgement]’.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 668-669.

However, Jesus is not telling his disciples to never exercise moral discernment and make decisions as a result. One could not follow any of the other teachings of Jesus without such discernment. Dallas Willard (in *The Divine Conspiracy*) captured well the precise nuance that Jesus is going after here:

“What is it, exactly, that we do when we condemn someone? We really communicate that he or she is, in some deep and just possibly irredeemable way, bad—bad as a whole, and to be rejected. He or she is not acceptable. We sentence that person to exclusion. ... Now, to be fair, we rarely intend such total rejection, but that is what usually comes across. And to correct another person without making that happen requires great spiritual and personal maturity.”

Willard, Dallas (1998). [*The Divine Conspiracy: Rediscovering Our Hidden Life In God*](#). Harper. 218.

“Note Paul’s expression of Jesus’ teaching in Galatians 6:1: ‘Brothers, if someone really is caught in a sin, the spiritual ones among you are the ones to restore him. Do it in a humble and non-presumptuous spirit, considering yourselves, lest you too be put to the test. Feel the weight others are feeling, and thus you will fulfill Christ’s teaching.’

1. Don’t try to correct someone unless you are absolutely sure. If love ‘hopes all things’ (1 Cor. 13), and there is any lack of clarity, assume you’re wrong.
2. Correction is reserved for those in whom God’s spirit has produced the fruit of humility and gentleness.
3. Only what serves the purpose of helping them see clearly the teachings of Jesus should be mentioned.
4. The one attempting to correct should know certainly that they themselves could be caught in the same trap; i.e., any sense of self-righteousness is absent; the motive is purely compassion and that person’s well-being. This is the point of ‘feeling their burden.’

Condemnation always involves some degree of self-righteousness and distancing ourselves from the one we're condemning. ... Contempt is a major part of condemnation, and when we drop contempt from our soul, condemnation rarely occurs.

We must beware of the idea that it's okay for us to condemn as long as we are condemning the right things. It's not so simple as all that. I can trust Jesus to go into the temple and drive out those who were distorting its purpose with a whip. I cannot trust myself to do so."

Adapted from Willard, Dallas (1998). [*The Divine Conspiracy: Rediscovering Our Hidden Life In God*](#). Harper. 221.

Condemnation most often results in shame, not restoration.

Matthew 7:1: " ... so that you will not be judged."

- The passive verb "be judged" is likely a "divine passive." Meaning, God will hold us accountable based on the criteria by which we have evaluated others.
- God will hold you accountable for how you treat people. This idea is fleshed out in the following explanation.

This last line also introduces the idea that any and all of our judgments are always provisional and could be incorrect, given that we don't know the depths of people's hearts and the details of their stories.

If you evaluate the behavior of others by a double standard, judging their behavior as wrong but not applying that same standard to yourself, you will be held accountable.

"The measure by which you measure" (Greek: *metron* / *metreo*): In this line, Jesus uses vocabulary from the marketplace, measurements of grain or commodities, but he also adopts a well-known traditional saying from Second Temple and later rabbinic Judaism.

Babylonian Talmud, Sanhedrin 100a:

"In a related matter, it is taught in a baraita that Rabbi Meir says: In accordance with the measure that a person metes out for others the heavenly court metes out for him, i.e., the response is commensurate with the action."

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers.

2 Enoch 44:5 NRSVCE

Because on the day of the great judgment, every weight and every measure and every set of scales will be just as they are in the market. That is to say, **each will be weighed in the balance**, and each will stand in the market, **and each will find out his own measure and in accordance with that measurement** each shall receive his own reward.

The Speck in the Eye

a ³ Why do you **see** **the speck** in **the eye of your brother** ,
 but you don't **perceive** **the beam** in your eye!

b ⁴ Or, how can you say to **your brother** ,
 "Allow me **to take out** **the speck** from **your eye** ."

c And look, **the beam** is in **your eye** !

b' ⁵ Hypocrite! First **take out** **the beam from** **your eye** ,
 a' and then you can **see-clearly** **the speck** in **the eye of your brother** .

Matthew 7:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Vivid parable using images from the carpenter's workshop: speck (tiny dust speck), splinter, chip, plank (beam, stud).

"The robust imagery ... makes two related points: (1) the inappropriateness of drawing attention to another's failing when your own is much greater and (2) the insincerity of an offer to help, until your own greater problem has been dealt with. It is not wrong to notice or to try to help with another's failing, but the person who ignores or is unaware of their own greater failing is in no position to do so."

France, R. T. (2007). *The Gospel of Matthew (The New International Commentary on the New Testament)*. Eerdmans. 275.

What exactly does the metaphorical "beam" refer to?

- Your own sin, of a different kind or degree from the other ([France](#))
- Your critical eagerness to find fault with another ([F.D. Bruner](#), [Willard](#))

Here, "brother" means another disciple in the community. This is key. Jesus' disciples are to hold each other up to the standards of Jesus' teaching and help each other do so. It says nothing about people's behavior outside the community.

Matthew 7:5 makes clear that Jesus does expect that his disciples will "judge" one another's behavior and initiate conversation about it. But the process of recognizing your own "plank", owning up to it fully, and beginning to deal with it marks a person, humbles them, and gives them a mercy that invites transparency from the other.

Before setting out to hunt mole hills in faraway places, one should be able to see the mountain before one's face. ([Davies & Allison, 673](#))

"Human beings unhappily possess an inbred proclivity to mix ignorance of themselves with arrogance towards others." ([Davies & Allison, 673](#))

Jesus' teaching here draws upon common themes in Second Temple and rabbinic Judaism.

Babylonian Talmud, Qiddishin 70a:

"And Shmuel says: If one habitually claims that others are flawed, he disqualifies himself with his own flaw. The flaw he accuses them of having is in fact the one that he has."

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers.

Babylonian Talmud, Arakin 16b:

"R. Tarfon said, I wonder whether there is any one in this generation who accepts reproof, for if one says to him: Remove the mote (qêšām) from between your eyes [or: teeth], he would answer: Remove the beam (qôrā) from between your eyes."

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers.

Holy Pearls and Pig-Dogs: A Riddle

A' a 6 **Do not** give what is holy to **dogs** ,
b and don't throw your pearls in front of **pigs** ,
b' so **they** don't trample them with their feet,
a' and turning around, **they** will tear you apart.

Matthew 7:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

As a conclusion to all that has gone before in [7:1-5](#), Matthew now adds a short riddle from Jesus that mixes things up. If, when evaluating the behavior of others, one is not to be arrogant and severe toward them (as in [7:1-2](#)) or ignorant about one's own flaws (as in [7:3-5](#)), then neither is one to be totally indiscriminate and careless.

We need to exercise prudence and discernment about whether the person we're talking to will even receive what we have to offer. Jesus draws upon a set of well-known motifs and crafts his own riddle in response.

Who or What Are the Dogs and Pigs?

In ancient Judaism, dogs and pigs were often matched as a pair of ritually impure animals, not to be eaten by Torah-observant Israelites. Dogs were not primarily known as pets, but as wild scavengers that roamed the streets looking for refuse. Calling someone a dog was a form of insult or a denigrating way to describe a hostile person.

1 Samuel 17:42-43 NASB

When the Philistine looked and saw David, he disdained him; for he was but a youth, and ruddy, with a handsome appearance. The Philistine said to David, **"Am I a dog, that you come to me with sticks?"** And

the Philistine cursed David by his gods.

Psalm 22:20 NASB

Deliver my soul from the sword,
my only life from **the power of the dog.**

Psalm 22:16 NASB

For **dogs have surrounded me;**
a band of evildoers has encompassed me;
they pierced my hands and my feet.

Psalm 59:6 NASB

They return at evening, they **howl like a dog,**
and go around the city.

They were also considered impure in Jewish tradition, primarily due to their scavenging eating habits, and so a contrast to the sacred.

Exodus 22:31 NASB

You shall be holy men to me, therefore you shall not eat any flesh torn to pieces in the field; you shall throw it to the **dogs.**

1 Kings 14:11 NASB

Anyone belonging to Jeroboam who dies in the city **the dogs will eat.** And he who dies in the field the birds of the heavens will eat; for the LORD has spoken it.

1 Kings 21:19 NASB

You shall speak to him, saying, "Thus says the LORD, 'Have you murdered and also taken possession?'" And you shall speak to him, saying, "Thus says the LORD, 'In the place where **the dogs licked up the blood** of Naboth **the dogs will lick up your blood,** even yours.'"

Proverbs 26:11 NASB

Like a **dog** that returns to its vomit is a fool who repeats his folly.

Isaiah 66:3 NASB

But he who kills an ox is like one who slays a man;
he who sacrifices a lamb is like the one who breaks a **dog's neck;**
he who offers a grain offering is like one who offers a **pig's blood;**
he who burns incense is like the one who blesses an idol.
As they have chosen their own ways, and their soul delights in their abominations,

2 Peter 2:22 NASB

It has happened to them according to the true proverb,
"A **dog** returns to its own vomit," and,

“A **pig**, after washing, returns to wallowing in the mire.”

In Second Temple Jewish literature, the word “dog” could be used as a term of contempt, showing the animal-like character of a person.

Philippians 3:2 NASB

Beware of the **dogs**, beware of the evil workers, beware of the false circumcision;

Revelation 22:15 NASB

Outside are the **dogs** and the sorcerers and the immoral persons and the murderers and the idolaters, and everyone who loves and practices lying.

Odes of Solomon 28:13-15 NRSVCE

Because I continually did good to every man I was hated.

And **they surrounded me like mad dogs**, those who in stupidity attack their masters.

Because their mind is depraved, and their sense is perverted.

It was a common theme in later Jewish rabbinic literature that the sages were not to waste Torah-meditations on non-Israelites who were not interested or who did not value the Scriptures.

Babylonian Talmud, Hagigah 13A:

“And said R. Ammi, Teachings of the Torah are not to be handed over to gentiles: ‘He has not done so with any nation, and as for his ordinances, they have not known them.’ (Ps. 147:20).”

Neusner, Jacob (2011). [*The Babylonian Talmud: A Translation and Commentary*](#). Hendrickson Publishers. 52.

Tanhuma B

TanḥumaB 6 וירא (44B):

R. Judah the Levite b. Shalom (ca. 370) said, “Moses desired that the Mishnah (here = oral, traditional teaching) also be given in writing. But since God foresaw that one day the nations of the world (here = Christian world) would translate the Torah and read it in Greek and say, ‘We are (the true) Israel,’ He said to Moses, ‘If I wrote down for you the whole fullness of my teaching, in that case they (the Israelites) would be esteemed as the stranger’ (Hos. 8:12, so the Midrash). And all this why? Because oral teaching is the secret of God, and his secret God delivers only to the pious; see ‘The secret of God to those who fear him’ (Ps. 25:14).”

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press. 499-500.

Sometimes non-Israelites were called “dogs” in later rabbinic literature:

Midrash Psalm 4, section 11 (24A):

R. Joshua b Levi (ca. 250) said, “Like a king who held a meal and had the guests enter and sit down at the entrance of his palace. When they saw how the dogs came out with pheasants and heads of capons and calves in their mouth, they began to say, ‘If this is for the dogs, how much more at the banquet itself!’ And the nations of the world are like the dogs, as it says, ‘The dogs are very greedy’ (Isa. 56:11). If they exist in comfort in this world, will this all the more be the case with Israel in the future?”

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press. 824.

“Pirke Rabbi Eliezer 29: Whoever eats together with an idolater is like one who eats together with a dog; as the dog is uncircumcised, so too the idolater is uncircumcised.”

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press. 825.

While “dogs” is sometimes used for non-Israelites in Second Temple Jewish literature, it does not seem likely that this is its meaning in [Matthew 7:6](#), despite the title “little dog” given to the Canaanite woman in [15:26-27](#).

- More likely, it is a reference to the mixed character of the disciple community (explored again in [13:24-30](#)), where there may be followers, even leaders, whom Jesus doesn’t recognize (as in [7:21-23](#)).

What Are the Holy Things and Pearls?

The “holy things” and “pearls” are likely references to Jesus’ teaching or the gospel about the Kingdom (recall that “pearl” was a metaphor for God’s Kingdom in [Matthew 13](#)), or, more specifically, the constructive criticism a disciple might offer to another based on the moral worldview taught by Jesus.

In later rabbinic literature, “pearls” was a common image for wisdom sayings from the sages.

Babylonian Talmud, Hagigah 3A:

“R. Yohanan b. Beroqah (ca. 110) and R. Eleazar (ben) Hosma once went to greet (their teacher) R. Joshua (ca. 90) in Pekiin. He said to them, ‘What was new today in the house of teaching?’ ... and he said to them, ‘A beautiful pearl (מרגלית טובה) was in your hand, and you wanted to deprive me of it!’”

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press. 825.

The contrasting metaphor pair “holy-dogs” was used elsewhere in Jewish literature of the same period:

Mishnah, Temurah 6:5: “No one redeems a holy thing to feed it to the dogs.”

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press.

Babylonian Talmud, Bekhorot 15a: “We may not redeem a sacrifice that has been dedicated [to God] only in order to feed it to dogs.” (quoted later in Pesakhim 29a)

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press.

In these passages from the Talmud, “the holy thing” equals “sacred meat” from a dedicated and holy sacrifice. Jesus appears to be adopting this well-known image, but adapting its meaning to refer to the purity-impurity that depends upon the state of a person’s heart, and thus affects their ability to hear personal criticism.

Matthew 15:11 Instructor’s Translation

It is not what enters into the mouth that makes a person impure, but what proceeds out of the mouth, this makes the person impure.

How does Matthew 7:6 relate to all of 7:1-6?

The saying in Matthew 7:6 is a “counterbalance to the prohibition of one-sided criticism in v. 1-5: There may be times and situations when a responsible assessment of the likely response requires the disciple to limit their instinctive generosity, so that the holy things are not brought into contempt.” ([France, 277](#)).

The disciples’ shaking the dust from their feet in response to rejection is a possible example (in 10:14), also practiced by Paul (in Acts 13:46).

“While we should not prejudge who may receive one’s message, neither should one try to force it on those who show no inclination to accept it.”

Keener, Craig S. (2009). [The Gospel of Matthew: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary](#). Eerdmans. 277.

What exactly is the contrast?

- “Dogs vs. sacred”: contrasting ritually impure vs. pure [cf. Exod. 22:31, where impure meat is thrown to dogs.]
- “Pigs + pearls”: contrasting impure, unvalued animals vs. valuable and precious items. Jesus compared the Kingdom of God to a pearl (Matt. 13:45-46), a supremely precious thing.

What does the “trampling” refer to? The image is wholly within the parable, but the idea of harm or danger does seem to be the key idea of the metaphor. People who don’t discriminate between what they share and who they share it with are liable to get hurt, not to mention sharing the message with someone who’s not ready to care.

“The saying is an admonition about the necessity to discerning how much time and energy we direct towards people we know are resistant to direct conversations about the kingdom of God. The gospel of the kingdom—in 13:45–46 the kingdom is a pearl—was to be preached to all; but its heralds were also instructed to shake the dust off their feet when they were not received into a house or town (10:14). They were not to throw away wittingly the words of the gospel. They were not to give that which is holy to dogs or to throw pearls before swine (so Luther). There has to be an economy of truth.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark International. 676.

When considering all of 7:1-6 together, one is reminded of the rhetorical puzzle in Proverbs 26:4-5, which places two opposite sayings next to each other, forcing the reader to meditate on the difference.

Proverbs 26:4-5 NASB

Do not answer a fool according to his folly,
or you yourself will be just like him.
Answer a fool as his folly deserves,
that he will not be wise in his own eyes.

Reflection Question

What is the flow of thought in Matthew 7:1-6, and what is Jesus trying to teach us about judgment?